Colossians 1:1–8 — Leader / Learner Guide

Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae · a one-page guide for leaders and learners

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

① Big Idea and Context

Big idea: The true gospel of God's grace produced faith, love, and hope in Colossae, and that gospel, centered in a Christ who is fully God and fully man, needs nothing added to it.

Paul writes from house arrest in Rome to a church he never visited, planted by Epaphras during Paul's Ephesian ministry (Acts 19:10). An early Gnostic-type teaching was pressing the believers to add "deeper knowledge," rules, and angelic mediators to Christ.

- **Who and when:** Paul (with Timothy) from Rome, about AD 60–62, one of four Prison Epistles.
- **The problem:** dualism (spirit good, matter evil) that denied either Christ's deity (Cerinthians) or His humanity (Docetists).
- **The answer:** the gospel they first heard, the grace of God in truth, is already true, worldwide, and fruitful.

② The Gospel at Work — Three Anchor Verses

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
1:2	*"To the saints and faithful brethren … Grace to you and peace"*	Saints by position, faithful in practice; grace and peace in all their dimensions.
1:4–5	*"your faith in Christ Jesus and the love … because of the hope laid up for you in heaven"*	Faith looks up, love looks out, hope looks ahead; secure hope fuels love.
1:6	*"constantly bearing fruit and increasing … the grace of God in truth"*	The gospel is universal, productive, personal, and all of grace.

Sister letters: Ephesians shows the body of which Christ is the Head; Colossians shows the Head of which the Church is the body.

Thanksgiving first: Paul thanks God for grace at work before he corrects a single error.

③ Teaching Flow

1. Background — Paul in Rome; the church founded through Epaphras; the five features of the heresy and its two branches.

2. The greeting (1:1–2a) — Paul, an apostle by God's will; Timothy our brother; saints and faithful brethren.

3. Grace and peace (1:2b) — Four dimensions of grace; three dimensions of peace (Rom. 5:1; Phil. 4:9; 4:6–7).

4. Faith, love, hope (1:3–5a) — Up, out, and ahead; love flows from the hope laid up in heaven.

5. The gospel and its messenger (1:5b–8) — The gospel's four marks; Epaphras the faithful fellow servant.

④ Clarify While Teaching

- **Textual variants:** v.2 NASB95 "from God our Father" (NKJV adds "and the Lord Jesus Christ"); v.7 NASB95 "on our behalf" (NKJV "on your behalf"). Neither changes doctrine.
- **Epaphras and Epaphroditus:** Epaphras may be a short form of the same name, but Epaphroditus of Philippi (Phil. 2:25) is generally regarded as a different man.
- **"Gnosticism":** the Colossian error was an early, Jewish-flavored form; full Gnosticism developed in the second century. Avoid overstating the label.
- **Seven churches:** the idea that all of Revelation 2–3's churches were founded during Paul's Ephesian ministry is possible but cannot be proved.

⑤ Discussion and Close

1. Which of the three, faith (up), love (out), or hope (ahead), needs the most attention in your life right now?
2. Why would a wrong view of matter lead to a wrong view of Jesus, and why does that matter for salvation?
3. According to verse 5, why did the Colossians love all the saints? What does that suggest about assurance and love?

Close: Next, Paul turns thanksgiving into petition (1:9–14), praying for knowledge that leads to a worthy walk. "The gospel … is constantly bearing fruit and increasing."

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